

RESEARCH PAPER · 01

The *Window.*

*Eighteen months
that decide
the decade.*

AI, agents, and soon robotics in the world of premium
and luxury houses serving HNWI clients.

A WORKING THESIS FOR INDEPENDENT HOUSES AND ATELIERS OF 10 TO 150
PEOPLE.

THE MARKET

Personal luxury contracted in 2024 for the first time outside COVID. The aspirational buyer has left. The top *0.1%* of clients now drives *37%* of spend.

THE WINDOW

The next *18 to 30 months*. By 2028 these products will be standardised, priced higher, harder to differentiate.

THE BUILD COST

A signature digital product now costs *€40K to €150K*. The same instrument cost *€5M* in 2022.

THE BIGGEST RISK

Not the technology. The *human layer*. Roughly 70% of large transformations fail from employee resistance, almost never from the tech.

THE THESIS

*The edge in this decade goes to the houses that treat AI as an instrument of *intimacy*, not of scale.*

A NOTE BEFORE THE NUMBERS

This is not a McKinsey report.

It is a working thesis. Thirteen years inside luxury houses and another decade mentoring the leaders who run them.

What follows is what I would tell a founder of a house of 10 to 150 people who sat down across from me and asked:
what is happening, what do we do, what will it cost.

The paper has one bias I will declare up front. The edge in this decade goes to houses that treat AI as an instrument of intimacy, not of scale.

— A. O.

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April 2026

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SECTION I

Where luxury *actually*
is.

April 2026.

2025 MARKET — BAIN-ALTAGAMMA

€1.44T

Roughly flat. Personal luxury contracted in 2024 for the first time since 2008, outside COVID.

Bain's central case for 2026 is a return to *3 to 5%* growth. Not a boom — a market catching its breath after a decade of price-led expansion that lost the room.

THE ASPIRATIONAL BUYER HAS WALKED OUT

Around **35%** cut or stopped
luxury purchases this year.

45% in China.

They now represent **61%** of the market — down 13
percentage points since 2013. The engine that drove
democratisation has seized up.

BCG-ALTAGAMMA 2025 — TRUE-LUXURY STUDY

O.I[%] *drive* 37[%]
of clients *of market spend.*

Average annual luxury spend in this group: €360,000. Rising to €500,000 with cars included.

GLOBAL HNWI

940,000 today.
1.4 million by 2030.

Holding around *€100 trillion*. Growing 9% per year.

They are the clients that matter. They are also the clients that most brands cannot currently identify, reach, or serve at the level they now expect.

*In the luxury industry, we deal with
customers who want for nothing, but
are looking for something.*

LUCA LISANDRONI · CEO, BRUNELLO CUCINELLI · ALTAGAMMA 2025

BOF-MCKINSEY · STATE OF FASHION 2026

~90%

of AI projects in fashion stall at the pilot phase.

Across all industries the figure is closer to *70 to 80%*. The fashion result reflects industry-specific weakness in scoping and adoption discipline. 46% of executives expect conditions to worsen.

EUROSTAT 2025 — EUROPEAN AI USAGE

55%
large firms (250+)

17%
small firms (10–49)

The gap exists because tooling, capital, and talent until recently favoured the large.

As of 2026 that is reversing. The small firm that moves now closes the gap before the large firm has time to compound.

BIS / EIB STUDY, 12,000 EUROPEAN FIRMS · 2026

+4% productivity
within a year.

No employment loss. The gain compounds.

This is the cleanest causal evidence we have. It belongs in
any boardroom conversation about whether to invest.

SECTION II

The *HNWI shift*
nobody is pricing
correctly.

A SINGLE PHRASE KEEPS APPEARING

Health as *wealth*.

Spending shifting from apparel toward wellness, longevity, design, fine art, hospitality, experiences. BCG projects *10%* growth over 18 months for categories aligned with this mindset.

WHAT HNWI CLIENTS WANT, ABOVE ALL

- **Managed expectations.**
- **A relationship** with specific personnel.
- **Convenience-driven** time savings.

The client wants to feel known, to speak to a human who remembers, and to have their time respected.

AI can serve all three. It can also destroy all three if deployed badly.

KLAUS · JOURNAL OF PRODUCT & BRAND MANAGEMENT

WHAT HNWIS ARE DOING WITH AI RIGHT NOW

45%

of consumers use AI for at least part of a buying journey. IBM, Jan 2026

4,700%

growth in shopping queries on generative AI platforms, 2024–25. McKinsey, BoF

85%

report higher satisfaction with AI-assisted shopping journeys.

83%

express concerns about privacy and data misuse.

The trust gap is the binding constraint.

A SECOND BEHAVIOUR THE HEADLINES MISS

The HNW client runs a private *due-diligence query* before the meeting.

They ask: *who is this firm, what do people say, what are the risks of working with them.* Whatever the AI says is what the client believes when they walk in.

Most boutique houses have never tested this. When they do, they discover the AI describes them *smaller than they are, less established than they are*, sometimes carrying stale coverage from years ago as if it were today's truth.

The fix is a quarterly ritual — probe, document, feed corrections through your GEO practice.

Agentic commerce is about being where customers are and being relevant at the right moment. It is changing our industry — sooner than we expected.

SABRINA HADJALI · LOUIS VUITTON · NRF 2026

SECTION III

What the *big groups* have already built.

You cannot compete on infrastructure. You need to know what is there — because the floor rises for everyone.

L V M H

"Quiet tech."

Four years with Google Cloud. A central data platform feeding 75 Maisons. Franck Le Moal's phrase, a parallel to *quiet luxury* — the technology enhances the experience without being visible in it.

- **MaIA** — internal GenAI assistant on Gemini, Imagen, GPT. *2M+ queries / month* across 40,000 employees.
- **Dior × Kahoona** — predictive segmentation on anonymous visitors. Best Business Prize, 2025 LVMH Innovation Award.
- **Louis Vuitton × Rigsters / OKCC** — GenAI 3D asset production from physical products.
- **Hennessy × OKCC** — robotic-arm personalisation of 40 numbered X.O decanters.
- **RIMOWA × Solaya** — AI 3D content for RE-CRAFTED luggage. Smartphone capture, under an hour.
- **Tiffany & Co.** — AI-powered inspiration tool for bespoke engraving.

Market cap held above €400B; outperformed CAC 40 by 25%+ across three years. Analysts attribute part of this resilience directly to the AI work.

KERING — MORE FRAGMENTED, MORE BRAND-LED

340 million
customer profiles.

Gucci, the aggressive front, reportedly using over 340M profiles for segmentation and predictive analytics.

Kering's *Environmental P&L* measures product-level environmental footprint and guides design.

Gucci's Chengdu flagship — *33 LED screens* with AI imagery merging Renaissance Florence and Sichuan landscapes. Immersive brand theatre that would have cost tenfold five years ago.

RICHEMONT — QUIETER, MORE OPERATIONAL

Cartier avoided *\$280M in excess stock.*

AI used during the pandemic for forecasting and clienteling.

The group runs a *centralised yet flexible governance model* for RPA and conversational AI. Partnerships with Salesforce and Google carry most of the stack.

Solomei AI.

A family-owned Italian house, ~€1.3B revenue, ~2,500 employees. Built its own *"humanistic technology"* company.

Callimachus — an SDK powering a page-less, menu-less, AI-native website that rebuilds itself around visitor intent. Public launch January 2026.

Three years of work. Five people dedicated.

Two mathematicians. One engineer. One artist. *One philosopher.*

That team composition is the thesis.

*The guiding thread of our work for
Human Artificial Intelligence has been,
and will continue to be, the pursuit of a
serene and hopeful attitude towards
technology.*

BRUNELLO CUCINELLI

We masked the brand names on six luxury websites, placed them side by side, and they all looked the same.

FRANCESCO BOTTIGLIERO · CEO, SOLOMEI AI

ALSO WORTH TRACKING

- **Estée Lauder × Jo Malone** — AI Scent Advisor on Vertex + Gemini. Conversational agent that maps natural language to olfactory data.
- **Zegna** — in-store ML personal assistant. *49 billion* outfit combinations, by appointment.
- **Loro Piana** — customer-facing AI for made-to-measure design.
- **DWS** — connected in-boutique laser engraving at 100+ sales points worldwide.
- **Ralph Lauren** — own AI shopping assistant, launched late 2025.

SECTION IV

The *technology* horizon.

Now · 24 months · five years.

WHERE WE ARE — Q2 2026

- **Foundation models** commercially reliable for clienteling assistance, copy, translation, structured reasoning. Inference cost down $\sim 10\times$ in 18 months.
- **Multimodal** production-grade for product photography, mood boards, catalogue workflows.
- **Agentic workflows** — real but patchy. PwC: 2026 is the year of measurable deployments.
- **Agentic commerce** — Shopify, OpenAI, Google, Perplexity all shipping. Bain: 30–45% of US consumers already use GenAI to research and compare.
- **Digital Product Passports** — EU Central Registry live July 2026.
- **EU AI Act** — fully applicable *2 August 2026*. Fines up to €35M or 7% of worldwide turnover.

NEXT 12 TO 24 MONTHS — THROUGH Q2 2028

- **Agentic commerce** matures from discovery to cart-to-checkout. *Generative Engine Optimisation* becomes a marketing budget line.
- **Voice and ambient interfaces.** Smart eyewear with multimodal AI enters luxury. LVMH, Kering, Richemont actively evaluating.
- **Digital twins.** Virtual ateliers, try-on, bespoke configurators normalise in watches, jewellery, fashion.
- **Hyper-personal AI client advisors.** AI augmenting human sales associates. McKinsey calls it the next EBITDA lever.
- **DPP integration.** Compliance-first projects that produce loyalty, authentication, resale, storytelling. The investment is inevitable. The return is optional.

THREE TO FIVE YEARS — 2028 TO 2031

- **Humanoid robotics** in luxury hospitality and high-touch manufacturing. Market: *€6.2B* → *€165B* by 2034. Costs from *50–250K* to *30–150K* per unit in one year.
- **Luxury use cases first:** precision-assembly support in watchmaking and jewellery. Hotel back-of-house. Warehousing. Private-residence service.
- **AI-designed materials** — generative design driving fabric, metallurgy, composite innovation. Nike, Adidas demonstrating; luxury follows in 2–4 years.
- **Private and local inference** becomes standard. *"My client's data never leaves my house"* becomes technically real.
- **Proprietary brand intelligence** — the most defensible asset becomes the curated *corpus*, not the model.

SECTION V

Why the small house *has the edge.*

10 to 150 people. Five structural advantages the big groups cannot buy.

FIVE ADVANTAGES

- **Decision speed.** A 40-person atelier can decide, build, deploy in weeks. By the time a group committee chooses a vendor, you have shipped v2.
- **Direct client intimacy.** You know your top 40 clients by name. You remember their daughter's wedding. The group cannot replicate this with CRM dashboards.
- **Brand coherence.** You do not have 75 Maisons to align. Your voice, aesthetic, craft are *one instrument*.
- **Cost compression.** A clienteling AI that cost €5M in 2022 now assembles for *€30–120K*. The Cucinelli team was five.
- **Defensibility through specificity.** Foundation models are commoditised. Your archive, métiers d'art, client relationships are not.

*Yes, AI and algorithms can help,
but nothing can beat the human
contact.*

VALERIANO ANTONIOLI · CEO, LUNGARNO COLLECTION · ALTAGAMMA
2025

A DISCIPLINE MOST AI PAPERS MISS

Some knowledge *should remain unwritten.*

Not everything the house knows belongs in the model. The reasons a watchmaker still finishes bridges by hand on parts nobody will ever see are partly economic, partly aesthetic, partly metaphysical.

Oral. Embodied. Present only in the apprenticeship of the next generation. The model cannot replace the lineage. It can only support it.

SECTION VI

What to *build*.

A product architecture for houses of 10 to 150.

THE SIGNATURE MOVE

One signature *instrument.*

A bottle. A case-back. A scent formula. A room. A ritual.
That instrument did more for the brand than a hundred
campaigns.

In the twenty-first century, that instrument is a *premium
digital product* built on AI and shaped to your craft. *A
product, not a chatbot.*

FOUR REASONS THIS IS THE PLAY

- **The cost has collapsed.** €5M in 2022 → €40–150K in 2026. The window: 2026 to 2028. Then standardised.
- **HNWI clients will pay for it.** 0.1% of clients drive 37% of spend. They pay for intimacy, theatre, time.
- **It is defensible.** Anyone buys a ChatGPT subscription. Nobody replicates your archive, your philosophy, the years of trust with a specific family.
- **The economics beat every other brand investment.** A campaign shoot: €80–200K, six-month life. A premium digital product: €40–150K, runs three to five years.

The houses that will matter in 2030 are not the ones with the best AI. They are the ones with the best product built on top of AI that still feels, unmistakably, like them.

A WORKING THESIS

Four instruments a small house can *build well*.

THREE TO SIX MONTHS · ONE AT A TIME

i.

The *Signature Brand Intelligence*

Embodies the founder's voice. Trained on archives, interviews, photographs, craft notes — a private corpus only the house can build.

ii.

The *Bespoke Visualisation Atelier*

For houses whose work is commissioned before it is seen.
Documented average-order-value lifts of *20 to 40%*.

iii.

The *Private Client Portal*

Every commission, document and conversation in one living space. An AI concierge curates — the founder remains the relationship.

iv.

The *Signature Consultation Experience*

In-room AI-augmented meeting tool. Surfaces the right reference the instant the client mentions it.

What sits *beneath* and *beyond* the signature.

TIER II · OPERATIONAL FOUNDATIONS

- *Internal GenAI assistant* for the team.
 - *Archive digitisation and GEO readiness.*
 - *Brand voice and governance system.*
 - *Generative content pipeline.* Replaces 60–80% of low-creative production. *40 to 70%* savings on annual content within a year.
-

TIER III · AMBITIONS · 12 TO 24 MONTHS

- *The fully adaptive brand universe.* A Solomei-class template, shaped to the house.
 - *The Sovereign Journal.* A private long-horizon AI companion in the practice's category.
 - *The Annual Atelier Report.* Citation asset for AI visibility, gift to the client.
-

Do not build three at once. Pick the one that matches your craft — build it well.

SECTION VII

Budget & revenue.

Real numbers, not aspirational ones.

THE HEADLINE · DELOITTE 2025

8% → 14% →

32%

Tech spend as % of revenue. 2024. 2025. Projected 2028.

Luxury historically sat at 2 to 3%. That is no longer defensible.

ANNUAL AI & DATA BUDGET · BY REVENUE BAND

REVENUE BAND	ANNUAL BUDGET	% REV.	YEAR-ONE DELIVERABLES
€1M – 5M	€30K – 120K	1.5 – 3%	One Tier 1 product (MVP) + Tier 2 foundations
€5M – 20M	€120K – 400K	1.5 – 2.5%	One full Tier 1 + Tier 2 + GEO
€20M – 80M	€400K – 1.6M	1.5 – 2.5%	Two Tier 1 + full Tier 2 + one Tier 3 initiated
€80M – 300M	€1.6M – 6M	1.5 – 2.5%	Full Tier 1, full Tier 2, two Tier 3, in-house AI lead

A NOTE ON COST PER DELIVERABLE

Build costs have fallen
roughly tenfold in 24 months.

A signature digital product that required **€5M** and a full engineering team in 2022 now assembles for a fraction of that figure with the right architecture.

The exact investment depends on scope, data readiness, and the level of craft the house demands. *That conversation belongs in the Diagnostic, not in a table.*

TWO WARNINGS ON THESE NUMBERS

One. *Data preparation.*

For SMEs the figure is closer to *40 to 60%* of any real AI project, loaded toward year one. The temptation is to skip the boring data work and go straight to the visible AI product. The single most expensive mistake possible. Year three regret comes here.

Budget *150 to 200%* of initial development for the five-year total cost.

Two. *Break-even.*

Now *1.2 to 3 years* on well-scoped projects (IDC). Whatever you build — instrument it. Measure it. Kill what does not work by month nine.

SECTION VIII

The stack.

No religious wars. The best stack is the one your team can run.

THREE REALISTIC CONFIGURATIONS

Starter

UP TO 25 USERS · €30–80K SETUP

Claude + GPT + Gemini through a router. Notion / Airtable knowledge base. Make / Zapier / n8n workflows. Midjourney, ElevenLabs, Whisper.

Professional

25–150 USERS · €120–500K SETUP

Enterprise APIs with zero-data-retention. LangGraph / CrewAI orchestration. Salesforce / Cegid Retail. Snowflake / Databricks. Arianee / EON for DPP. Adobe Firefly. Credo AI for governance.

Atelier-built

€500K+ · 50+ EMPLOYEES

Own AI engineers, small data team. Custom fine-tuning, private inference, proprietary agent infrastructure. Only justified when AI is part of the product itself.

THREE PRINCIPLES THAT OVERRIDE THE STACK

- **Vendor portability.** Do not lock into a single model provider. Prices and capabilities will shift every six months for the next three years.
- **Data sovereignty.** For Swiss, French, Italian houses serving HNWI clients — your client data does not leave the EU, or you have a written contractual chain of custody.
- **Human-in-the-loop by default.** Every outbound communication routes through a human approval step until you have 12 months of clean logs.

One CTO quoted €180,000 to migrate a single mid-sized luxury build off OpenAI when prices changed. The abstraction layer would have cost €4,000 to install.

SECTION IX

Process. Systems.
Governance.

THE SIX DOCUMENTS YOU NEED ON PAPER

- **1. Brand AI Charter.** One page. What AI may do, may not do, what requires human sign-off.
- **2. Data Handling Map.** What client data you have, where it lives, what trains on it. Required for EU AI Act & GDPR.
- **3. Voice & Aesthetics Style Guide** (for machines). Tone, example pairs of good and bad outputs, boundaries.
- **4. The Refusals Register.** What the house never does, regardless of price. Maintained by founder + senior craftsperson, signed annually.
The deepest piece of brand work the AI requires.
- **5. AI Literacy Training Records.** Required by Article 4 of the EU AI Act. From *2 August 2026*.
- **6. Risk Register.** Hallucination. Data leak. Brand drift. Regulatory non-compliance. Provider outage.

THE FOUR RITUALS THAT MAKE GOVERNANCE REAL

- **Monthly output review.** One hour a month. Founder reviews random sample of AI outputs across all channels. Skip this and the brand slips without you noticing.
- **Quarterly AI council.** 90 minutes. Operations, marketing, craft, data/tech, legal. Kill projects that aren't earning their keep.
- **Quarterly AI self-probe.** Probe what each major AI says about your firm. The single most cost-effective ritual you can put in the calendar.
- **Annual external audit.** Someone from outside asks the questions you have become too close to see.

SECTION X

The *human* layer.

Where the implementation will fail in practice. Not from technology. From *grief*.

MCKINSEY · LARGE TRANSFORMATIONS

70%

fail — primarily from employee resistance, not technology.

PwC: companies that build change management into AI rollouts see **30%** fewer delays and **25%** better productivity.

Stanford: AI literacy programmes need **40 to 60 hours** of role-specific training per employee. A webinar will not move the needle.

EVERY TRANSFORMATION IS A LOSS BEFORE IT IS A GAIN

This is grief. Not *resistance*.

The senior salesperson who has spent eighteen years writing letters in her own voice — asked to let a machine draft them first. *Grief, not resistance*.

The atelier head whose juniors used to come to him for research that now takes seconds. *Identity loss, not laziness*.

The marketing coordinator whose career was built on writing copy. *Professional bereavement, not technical hesitation*.

FOUR MOVES ON THE HUMAN LAYER

- **Naming the loss.** The founder must say this aloud, in person, in a room. An email will not do this work.
- **The 40–60 hour reality.** Plan and budget for proper training. For a 40-person house: *2,000 to 2,400 hours* across the team in year one.
- **New identities, not just new tools.** Salesperson → curator. Coordinator → editor and orchestrator. Junior researcher → senior judgment specialist.
- **Find solutions together.** Have the team identify their own most tedious tasks. The wins are theirs. Trust grows from there.

STRENGTHS – Founder-led decision speed – Coherent brand voice and aesthetic – Real intimacy with top clients – Defensible archive and craft corpus – No legacy tech debt – Ability to pick vendors and kill them	WEAKNESSES – Small talent pool. AI literacy often absent – Limited capital for multi-year bets – Data often fragmented or on paper – No in-house legal for EU AI Act – Founder attention is a bottleneck – Cannot match group-scale R&D
OPPORTUNITIES – HNWI demand for intimacy and time-saving – Falling AI build costs (10× in 24 months) – Health-as-wealth category expansion – GEO and agentic commerce discovery – DPP as storytelling asset, not just compliance – First-mover effect in your niche	THREATS – Aggregator-agent disintermediation – Brand homogenisation through bad AI – Data breach (e.g. Dior, May 2025) – EU AI Act fines up to 7% of turnover – Talent lost to groups or tech firms – Fast-moving regulation you cannot staff

SECTION XII

The risks *nobody* puts
on the glossy slide.

SIX RISKS

- **1. Brand dilution by a thousand outputs.** Cheap content trained on no clear voice erodes a brand faster than a bad campaign.
- **2. Data breach.** Christian Dior, May 2025: South Korean e-commerce database. Names, contacts, purchase history. A single breach can end client relationships built over 15 years.
- **3. Regulatory whiplash.** EU AI Act *2 August 2026*. CNIL fines up to €32M. The temptation is to wait — that has now become the expensive choice.
- **4. The agent-as-gatekeeper threat.** Amazon's *Buy for Me*, ChatGPT commerce. If you are not in the training data, you are absent from the consideration set.
- **5. Human capital erosion.** If your salespeople stop writing their own messages, the craft of personalisation decays. You lose them within three years and notice only when you need them back.
- **6. Founder over-reliance.** The practice becomes an extension of the founder's taste. Two weeks unavailable, the practice stalls. Institutionalise from month six.

SECTION XIII

A five-year
foresight.

BY 2028

- **Agentic commerce** is 15–25% of luxury e-commerce touchpoints (top of funnel). Closing remains human-assisted above €5,000.
- **DPP** is operationally live across fashion, footwear, jewellery, watches in the EU.
- **AI-assisted clienteling** is table stakes for HNWI-facing brands.
- **First humanoid deployments** in luxury atelier environments. Watchmaking leads. Jewellery follows.
- **EU AI Act** high-risk rules fully binding. At least 2–3 luxury groups have faced enforcement. The lesson is loud.

BY 2031

- **The top 20%** of luxury houses by growth have a signature AI product or experience that is part of their brand, not adjacent to it.
- **A handful of independent boutique houses** have outgrown mid-tier groups by serving 500 to 2,000 HNWI clients with intimacy that does not scale the old way.
- **Humanoids** in hospitality back-of-house and UHNW residences are normal. Front-of-house remains largely human, longer than vendors predict.
- **The proprietary AI corpus** — client data, archival knowledge, craftsman notes — has become a balance-sheet asset that investment memos reference.
- **Instruments of sovereignty.** AI-native products that help HNWI regulate their own attention, time, health, aesthetic environment.

SECTION XIV

How ELIA Atelier *works.*

ELIA Atelier accompanies independent houses through this transition. Three instruments, one principle: *build only what serves the craft.*

The Diagnostic.

A four-hour session with the founder, followed by team interviews. Delivered as a 15-to-20-page strategic document within 15 working days. An honest reading of where the house stands, a cartography of what AI can do for it, and three recommended priorities for the next twelve months.

The Signature System.

A premium digital product built on AI and shaped to the house's voice, archive, and craft. A product that did not exist before, that no other house can replicate.

The Strategic Presence.

Ongoing direction. A 90-minute session every two weeks with the founder. A written document formalising decisions after each session. Asynchronous access between sessions. The discipline to execute one project at a time and finish it before starting the next.

A WORKING CONCLUSION

Luxury did not survive three centuries by chasing every technology. It survived by choosing the technologies that served the craft and refusing the ones that diluted it.

The smartphone did not end the atelier. *AI will not be different.*

AI is the same test. The houses that get it right will still be here in 2040.

TWO WAYS TO BEGIN

A first conversation. *Private. Without a deck.*

Around thirty minutes. No deck. We meet, we look honestly,
we part well whether or not the next step is with us.

BOOK A CONVERSATION →

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